

Retrograde Urethrogram (RUG)

WARWIKI

Patient Instructions · What to expect before your X-ray of the urethra

A retrograde urethrogram — or “RUG” — is a short X-ray test that takes pictures of your urethra, the tube that carries urine out of your body. A small amount of dye is gently placed into the urethra so it shows up clearly on the X-ray. This helps your surgeon find and measure any narrowing, scar, or injury before planning your treatment.

About This Test

Scar tissue or a narrowing inside the urethra — called a **stricture** — can be hard to see on a regular scan. A RUG fills the tube with a special dye that shows up white on X-ray. This creates a clear “road map” of the inside of your urethra.

Your surgeon may order a RUG to:

- Find a narrowing or scar and measure exactly where it is and how long it is
- Check the urethra after an injury
- Plan a surgery to repair the urethra
- Check how the urethra is healing after a repair

The test shows the open channel inside your urethra — the path that urine takes. It does not look at the kidneys, and it is not a treatment; it is a picture that guides what comes next.

Is It Safe?

Yes. A RUG is a common, low-risk test. The amount of X-ray used is small, and the dye is water-based and leaves your body in your urine. Most people have only brief, mild discomfort. Uncommon side effects — a urine infection, a little bleeding, or trouble urinating for a short time — are usually mild and pass quickly.

LEARN THE TERMS

Urethra

The tube that carries urine from the bladder out of the body.

Stricture

A narrow or scarred spot in the urethra that can slow or block the flow of urine.

Contrast dye

A liquid that shows up white on X-ray so the inside of the urethra can be seen.

Catheter

A thin, soft tube. For this test, only the very tip sits just inside the opening — it does not go all the way in.

Fluoroscopy

A type of X-ray that shows live, moving pictures as the dye flows.

Meatus

The opening at the tip of the penis where urine comes out.

Urine culture

A quick test on a urine sample to check for infection before the test.

Reconstructive urologist

A surgeon who specializes in the urinary tract and in repairing the urethra.

WILL IT HURT? Most people feel only brief pressure or stinging as the dye goes in, not sharp pain. The team can slow down at any time — just tell them if you are uncomfortable. The test is over in about 15–30 minutes.

How to Get Ready (Before Your Test)

There is very little to do to prepare. In most cases:

- You can **eat and drink normally** — no need to fast unless your team tells you otherwise.
- Take your **usual medicines** unless your team asks you to stop something.
- You can usually **drive yourself home**, because no sedation is needed for most patients.

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Have ever had a reaction to X-ray contrast dye or iodine
- Take a blood thinner
- Have signs of a urine infection (burning, fever, or cloudy, strong-smelling urine) — an active infection may mean the test is rescheduled

You may be asked to give a **urine sample** to check for infection, and you may be given an **antibiotic** before or after the test to lower the small risk of infection.

What Happens During the Test

- 1 You lie on an X-ray table, usually turned slightly onto your side. The team helps you into position.
- 2 The tip of the penis is cleaned. A small, soft tube is placed **just inside the opening** — only the tip. A tiny balloon may be gently inflated to hold it in place.
- 3 The dye is slowly placed into the urethra while X-ray pictures are taken. You may be asked to hold still and breathe normally.
- 4 The team watches the dye on a screen and takes a few pictures from different angles. Then the tube is removed.

After the Test

- You can usually go home and return to **normal activities right away**.
- You may feel **mild burning when you urinate** for a day or so. Drinking extra water helps flush it out and eases this.
- You may notice a **small amount of blood** at the tip, or a pink tinge in your urine. This is common and usually clears within a day.
- The dye leaves your body in your urine over the next several hours.

Call your surgeon's office or seek care if you have:

- A fever or chills
- Trouble urinating, or you cannot urinate at all
- Heavy bleeding, or bleeding that will not stop
- Pain that gets worse instead of better

THREE THINGS TO REMEMBER

1. A RUG is a quick, safe X-ray that maps the inside of your urethra with a special dye — it helps your surgeon plan the right treatment.
2. There is little to do to prepare. Eat, drink, and take your usual medicines — but tell your team about any dye allergy, blood thinners, or signs of a urine infection.
3. Most people feel only brief pressure and go home right away. Mild burning or a little blood for a day is normal — drink extra water, and call for fever, heavy bleeding, or trouble urinating.